

Chapter 126

Using the Color Page

Given the origin of DaVinci Resolve as a professional grading application, the Color page is at the heart of the DaVinci Resolve experience.

Within the Color page are all of the controls available for manipulating color and contrast, reducing noise, creating limited secondary color corrections, building image effects of different kinds, adjusting clip geometry, and making many other corrective and stylistic adjustments.

In this chapter, you'll learn how to understand the Color page interface, how to customize it, and how to work within it to play through and navigate your project's timeline. You'll also learn how to analyze and compare clips in preparation for grading using stills, playheads, and DaVinci Resolve's own internal video scopes.

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The Color Page Interface

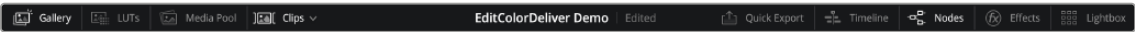
The Color page is divided into seven main areas that work together to let you build a grade. This section provides an overview of what these areas are and how they function.



The default layout of the Color page

The Interface Toolbar

At the very top of the Color page is a toolbar with buttons that let you show and hide different parts of the user interface. These buttons are as follows, from left to right:



The Interface toolbar



Gallery: Opens and closes the Gallery panel.



LUTs: Opens and closes the LUT Browser.



Media Pool: Opens and closes the Media Pool.



Clips: Opens and closes the Thumbnail timeline. To the right is a drop-down menu that lets you choose a timeline filtering option for the Thumbnail timeline.



Quick Export: Opens the Quick Export window.



Timeline: Opens and closes the Mini-Timeline.



Nodes: Opens and closes the Node Editor.



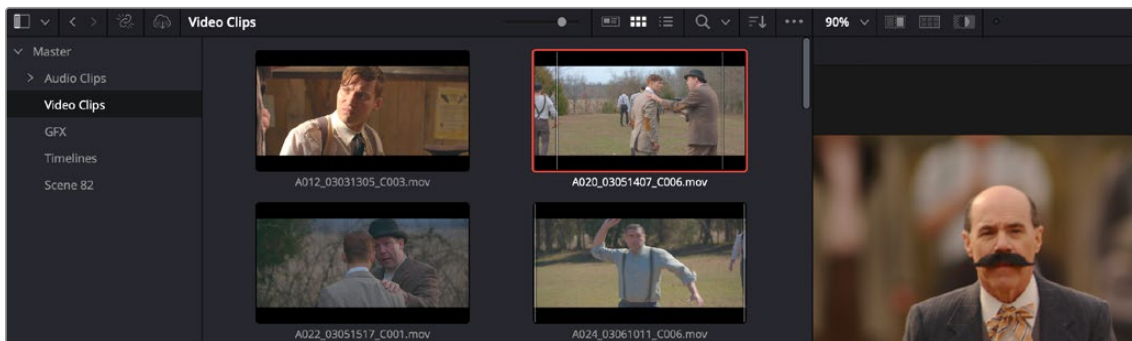
Open FX: Opens and closes the Open FX panel.



Lightbox: Opens and closes the Lightbox.

Showing Which Panel Has Focus

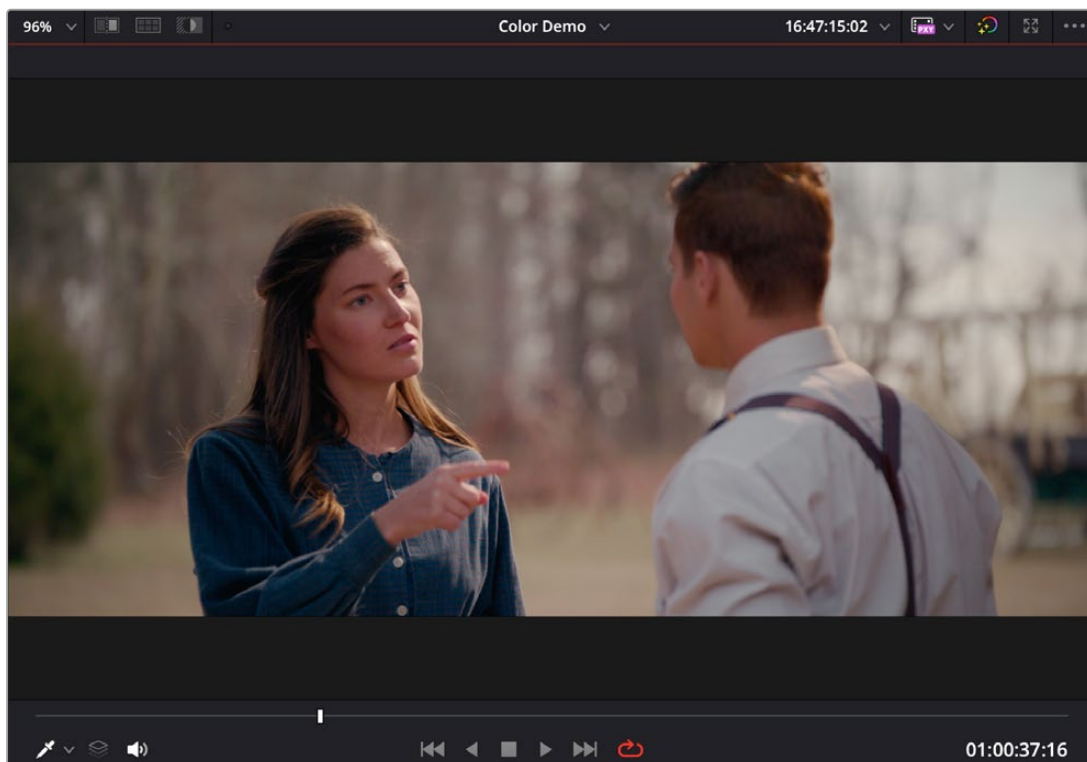
Whenever you click somewhere on the DaVinci Resolve interface using the pointer, or use a keyboard shortcut to “select” a particular panel (such as in the Edit page), you give that panel of the user interface “focus.” A panel with focus will capture specific keyboard shortcuts to do something within that panel, as opposed to doing something elsewhere in the interface. A highlight appears at the top edge of the panel to show you which panel has focus so that you can keep track of which part of the current page is taking precedence, and you can switch focus as necessary to do what you need to do. You can turn the Focus Indicator on and off in Preferences > User > UI Settings > Show focus indicators in the user interface.



The focus indicator shown at the top edge of the Media Pool, shown next to a Viewer that doesn't have focus

Viewer

The Viewer shows the frame at the current position of the playhead in the Timeline. At the top of the Viewer is a header that displays the Project and Timeline names, as well as a Viewer Timecode display that shows the source timecode of each clip by default. The Timeline name is also a drop-down display that lets you switch to any other timeline in the project. A scrubber bar underneath the image lets you drag the playhead across the entire duration of the clip, while transport controls underneath that let you control playback. A toolbar at the top provides controls governing Image Wipes, Split-Screen controls, and Highlight display. Additional controls let you loop playback, switch Unmix mode on and off, turn audio playback on and off, and choose which onscreen controls are currently displayed. More information about using the Viewer appears later in this chapter.



The default Viewer with transport controls

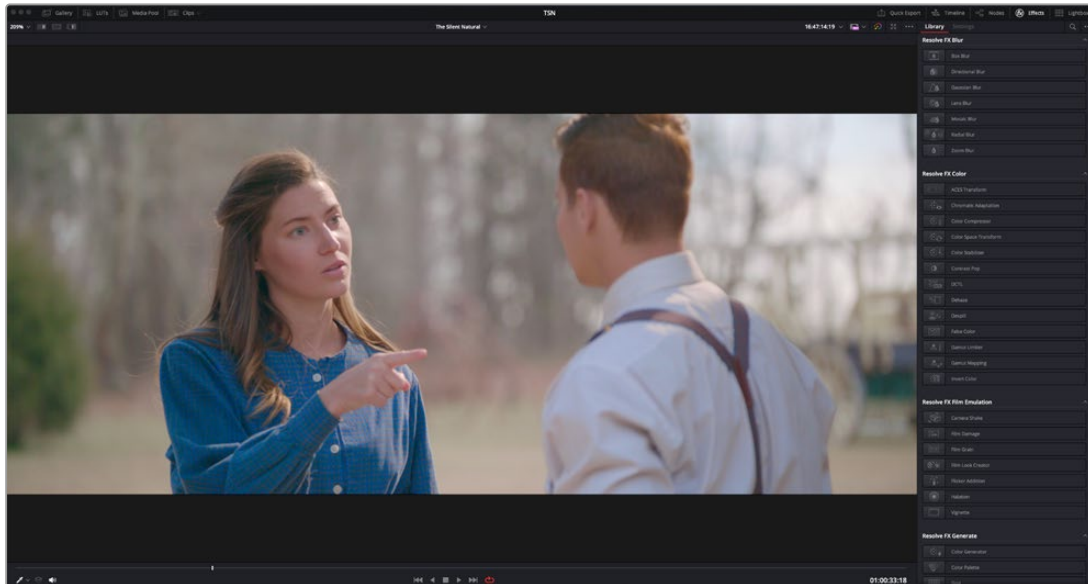
You can also put the Viewer into one of three alternate modes to be able to see a larger image as you work. All three of these modes are available from the Workspace > Viewer Mode submenu.

- **Enhanced Viewer:** (Option-F to toggle this on and off) hides everything to the left and right of the Viewer, giving you a large working area for tasks such as window positioning and roto-scoping, while keeping the palettes and their controls visible as you work.



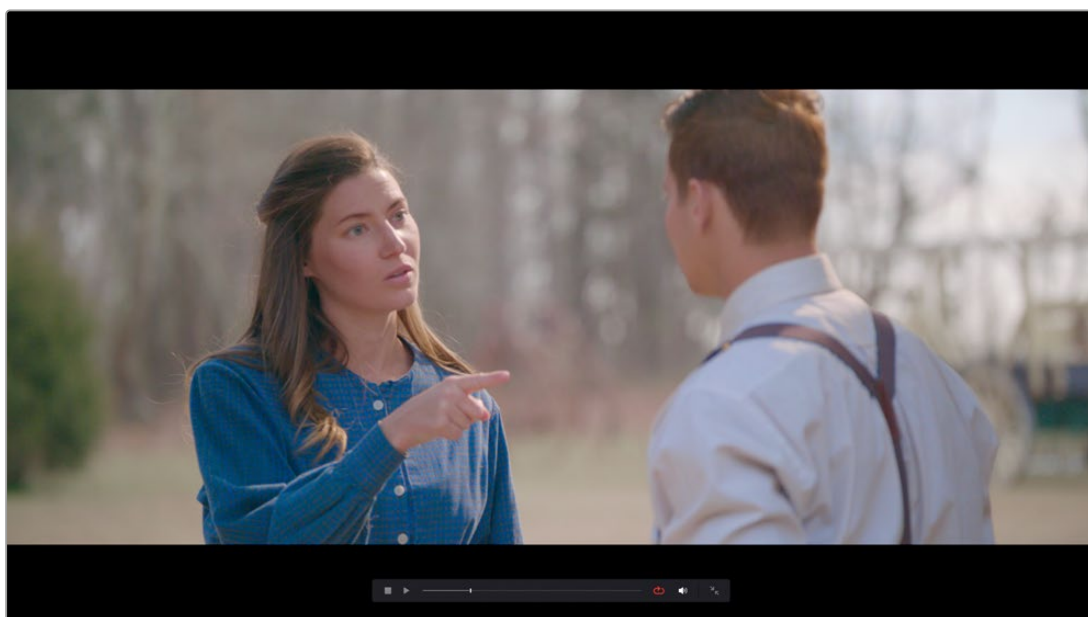
The Color page in Enhanced Viewer mode

- **Full Screen Viewer:** (Shift-F to toggle this on and off) is available to provide more working area for tasks such as window positioning and roto-scoping. Full Screen Viewer also lets you display the Effects panel at full height, and you can turn the Node Editor on and off to access different effects controls while you work.



The Color page in Full Screen Viewer mode

- **Cinema Viewer:** (P to toggle this on and off) expands the Viewer to fill your workstation's entire monitor. This is useful if you want to play the current Timeline without any distractions. When you move the pointer over the image, transport controls and a jog bar appear to let you control playback. For DITs, a contextual menu is available by right-clicking anywhere on the image with which you can turn on and customize a video scope overlay (which can be dragged to different locations on the Viewer).



The Color page in Cinema Viewer mode

Gallery

The Gallery is used for storing still frames to use as reference, and grades you might like to copy; stills and grades are stored together. A button lets you open up the Album browser, used for organizing your stills. At the bottom of the Gallery, Memories let you store grade information that you can apply using a control panel or keyboard shortcuts. The Gallery on the Color page mirrors the contents of the Gallery page.

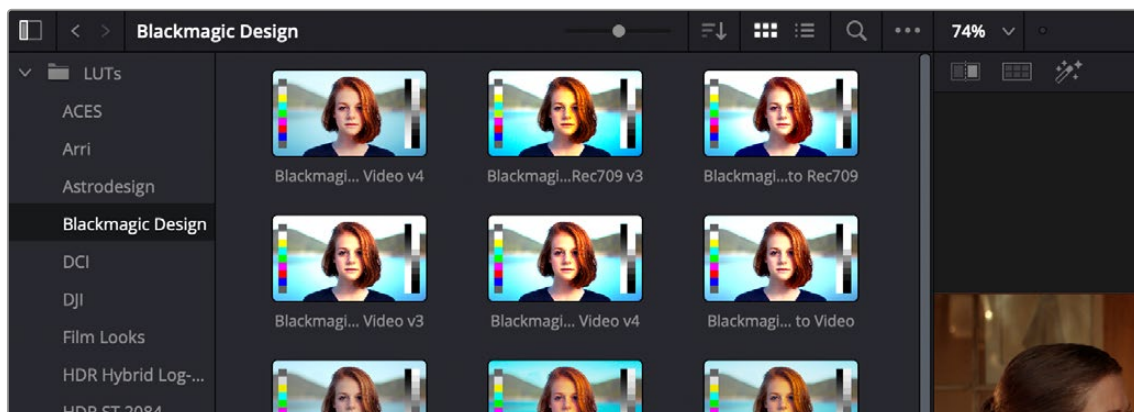
For more information on the Gallery page, see *Chapter 141, “Using the Gallery.”*



The Gallery has Memories, stills saved in albums and your PowerGrades

LUT Browser

The LUT Browser provides a centralized area for browsing and previewing all of the LUTs installed on your workstation. All LUTs appear in the sidebar, by category.



The LUT Browser

By default, all LUTs appear with a test thumbnail that give a preview of that LUT's effect, but you can also get a live preview of how the current clip looks with that LUT by hover scrubbing with the pointer over a particular LUT's thumbnail (this is described in more detail below).

To open the LUT Browser:

Click the LUT Browser button in the UI Toolbar at the top of the Color page.

Methods of working with the LUT Browser:

To see the LUTs in any category: Click on a LUT category to select it in the sidebar, and its LUTs will appear in the browser area.

To make a LUT a favorite: Hover the mouse over a LUT and click the star badge that appears at the upper right-hand corner, or right-click any LUT and choose Add to Favorites. That LUT will then appear when you select the Favorites category.

To search or filter for specific LUTs: Open a bin that has the LUT you're looking for, then click the magnifying glass icon to open the search field, and type text that will identify the LUTs you're looking for.

To see LUTs in Column or Thumbnail view: Click the Column or Thumbnail buttons at the top right of the LUT Browser to choose how to view LUTs in the browser area.

To sort LUTs in Thumbnail view: Click the Thumbnail Sort drop-down menu and choose which criteria you want to sort LUTs by. The options are Filename, Type, Relative Path, File Path, Usage, Date Modified. There are also options for ascending and descending sort modes.

To sort LUTs in Column view: Click the column header to sort by that column. Click a header repeatedly to toggle between ascending and descending modes.

To update the thumbnail of a LUT with an image from a clip: Choose a clip and frame that you want to use as the new thumbnail for a particular LUT, then right-click that LUT and choose Update Thumbnail With Timeline Frame.

To reset the thumbnail of a LUT to use the standard thumbnail: Right-click a LUT and choose Reset Thumbnail to go back to using the standard test image.

To refresh a LUT category with new LUTs that may have been installed: Select a LUT category, then right-click anywhere within the browser area and choose Refresh to refresh the contents of that category from disk.

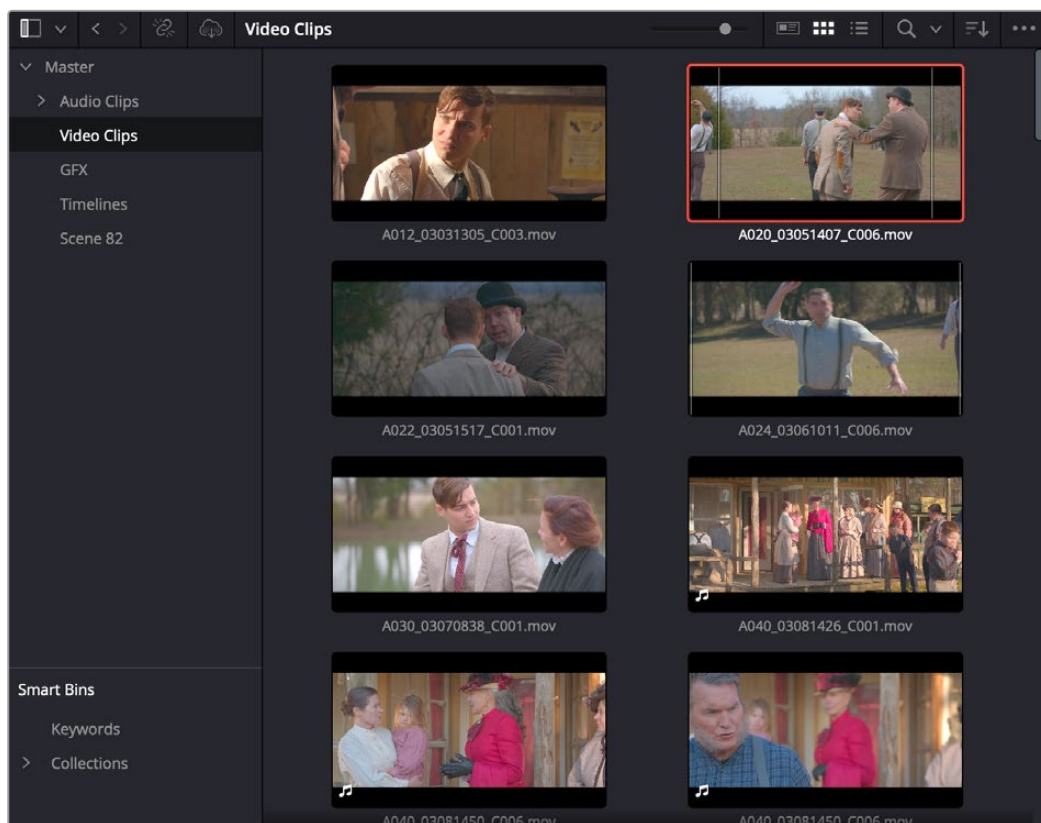
Methods of adding LUTs to a grade from the LUT Browser:

To apply a LUT to the current node: Select a clip in the Thumbnail timeline, then right-click a LUT and choose Apply LUT to Current Node from the contextual menu.

To apply a LUT to a specific node: Drag a LUT from the LUT Browser and drop it onto the node you want to apply a LUT to. If you drag a LUT onto a node that already has a LUT, the previous LUT will be overwritten by the new one.

Media Pool

The Media Pool is available in the Color page, making it easy to drag and drop clips you want to use as external mattes right into the Node Editor, for easy and fast connection to create various Color page effects. When opened, the Media Pool replaces the Gallery, fitting into the same area. In most respects, the Media Pool in the Color page works the same as the Media Pool on nearly every other page of DaVinci Resolve.



The Media Pool is available in the Color page.

When you drag a clip from the Color page Media Pool to the Node Editor, two things happen:

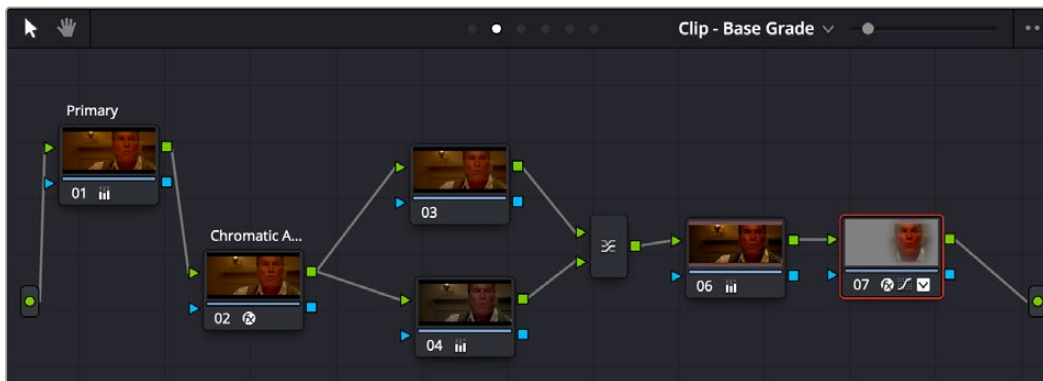
- That clip is turned into an external matte in the current grade, which you can use as a matte for secondary adjustments, or as a compositing layer (in conjunction with the Layer mixer) for mixing textures or images with your grade.
- That clip is also automatically attached to the Media Pool clip that corresponds to the clip you're grading as a clip matte, to help you keep track of which clips are using other clips as mattes.

For more information about the Media Pool, see *Chapter 18, "Adding and Organizing Media with the Media Pool."*

Node Editor

The Node Editor is where you assemble one or more individual corrections (nodes) together into a complete multi-correction grade (node tree). This is a powerful way of assembling grades, since different types of nodes let you create different combinations of corrections and very specific adjustments by reordering operations, combining keys, or changing the layer order of different adjustments.

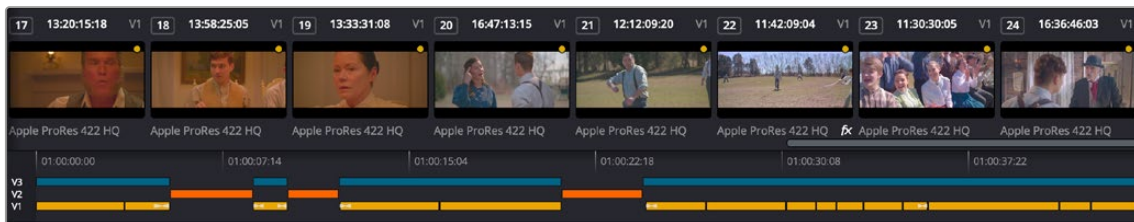
For more information about the Node Editor, see *Chapter 143, “Node Editing Basics.”*



Node Editor to construct your grade processing signal flow

Timeline

The Timeline provides several ways of navigating the clips in your project, as well as keeping track of what has been done to which clips. The Timeline is divided into two parts, each of which shows different information and provides differing controls, and each of which can be opened or closed separately via the Clips and Timeline buttons on the Interface toolbar.

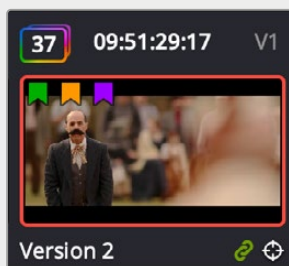


The Thumbnail timeline with a Mini-Timeline below

Thumbnail Timeline

At the top is the Thumbnail timeline, in which each clip is represented by a single frame. The Thumbnail timeline (or its alter-ego, the Lightbox) provides the easiest way of selecting which clip you want to work on and of making clip selections for various grade management operations. The currently selected clip that reveals its controls in the various palettes of the Color page is highlighted in orange.

Much valuable information appears above and below each thumbnail, such as each clip's clip number, source timecode, track number, whether it's been flagged, whether it's automatically linked or part of a group, whether it's been tracked, and so on.



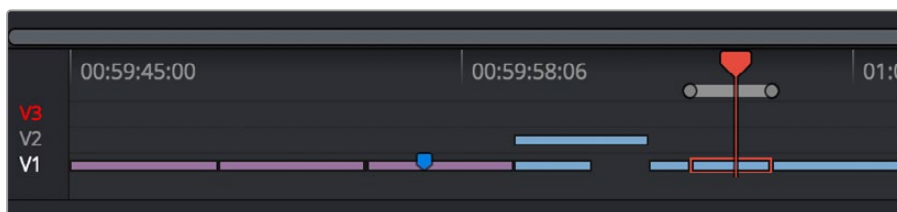
A clip thumbnail in the Thumbnail timeline

What's displayed underneath each thumbnail can be changed by double-clicking the space underneath each thumbnail. There are several options; you can keep double-clicking to cycle among them:

- Clip format or codec (the default)
- Clip Name (clip name or file name, depending on what View > Show File Names is set to) or Multicam Angle (if you're working with multicam clips)
- Version name or number

Mini-Timeline

Underneath, the Mini-Timeline shows a small representation of the video tracks of the Timeline in the Edit page wherein each clip is as long as its actual duration. This provides the best representation of the structure of the current timeline, in which clip length shows duration and multiple tracks are displayed, so you can see which clips are superimposed. A Timeline Ruler lets you scrub the playhead across multiple clips and can be zoomed out enough to show every clip in your entire program.



The Mini-Timeline lets you see timeline structure, and small track header controls let you enable tracks, disable tracks, and set the playhead to ignore specific tracks

Small track labels at the left of each track in the Mini-Timeline let you enable or disable tracks by clicking them (enabled tracks have white labels, disabled tracks have gray labels). Option-clicking one of these controls sets that track to be enabled but ignored by the playhead when you use the Next and Previous Clip commands, in the event you want to ignore clips you don't need to grade (tracks in this mode show a red label).

Within the Mini-Timeline the currently selected clip is highlighted in orange, and you can click any clip to select it. A scroll bar at the bottom lets you navigate to the left and right, while using the scroll wheel of your mouse zooms in and out. The Mini-Timeline shows at most six tracks of video. If your project has more tracks than that, you can scroll up and down to reveal the hidden tracks. Any markers that were placed on clips or the Timeline in the Edit page appear here, and you can click any marker to reveal and edit its color and notes.

As seen above, a colored outline appears around the clip number of shots that have been graded, and this outline is doubled if there are additional versions applied to that clip.

For more detailed information about the Color page Timeline, see *Chapter 126, “Color Page Timeline and Lightbox.”*

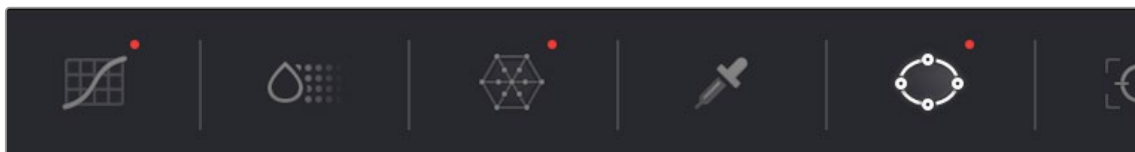
Palette Area

Most everyday tools and functions for grading are distributed among a series of palettes found in the palette area of the Color page. These palettes can be accessed via a series of palette buttons running along the Palette bar at the top of this area.



All palettes seen in the Palette bar

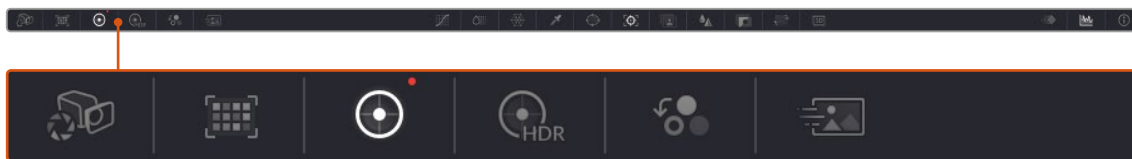
These buttons also give you feedback about which palettes have adjustments for the current selected node in the Node Editor. Palettes with adjustments show a small orange dot in the corresponding palette button.



An orange dot in a palette button lets you know there are adjustments in that palette

Left Palettes

A series of palettes at the bottom left of the Color page provide access to different sets of grading tools, used principally for manipulating color, contrast, and raw media format settings. Each individual palette is opened by clicking the corresponding icon at the top of the Palette panel.



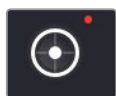
Left palette selection buttons



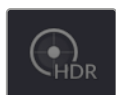
Camera Raw palette: For making metadata adjustments to raw media formats



Color Match palette: Automatic grading based using test charts



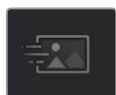
Primaries: Graphical color balance controls and master wheels, along with a Slider mode for adjusting YRGB Lift/Gamma/Gain



HDR palette: Advanced primary grading controls designed for wide-gamut media and SDR or HDR mastering



RGB Mixer: For mixing color channels into one another



Motion Effects palette: With controls for noise reduction and artificial motion blur

The five available palettes can be used individually or together depending on what you're trying to accomplish.

For more information on most of these palettes, see *Chapter 129, "Primaries Palette."*

For more information on the Motion Effects palette, see *Chapter 153, "The Motion Effects and Blur Palettes."*

Center Palettes

At 1920x1080 resolution or higher, a second set of palettes is organized at the bottom center of the Color page. These palettes span a

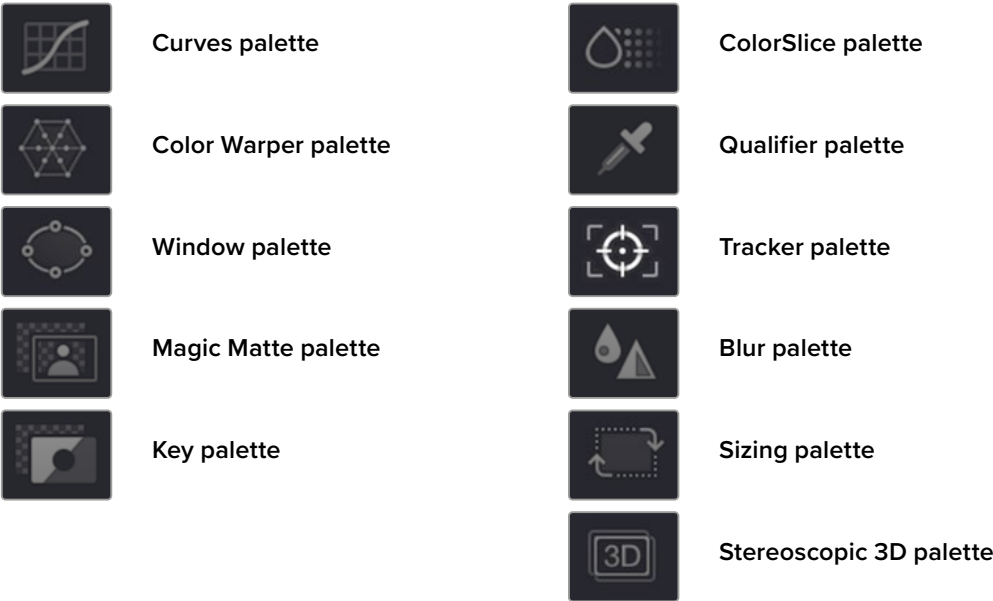
range of functionality, and the adjustments you make with them can be combined with those made using the Color palettes.



Center palette selection buttons

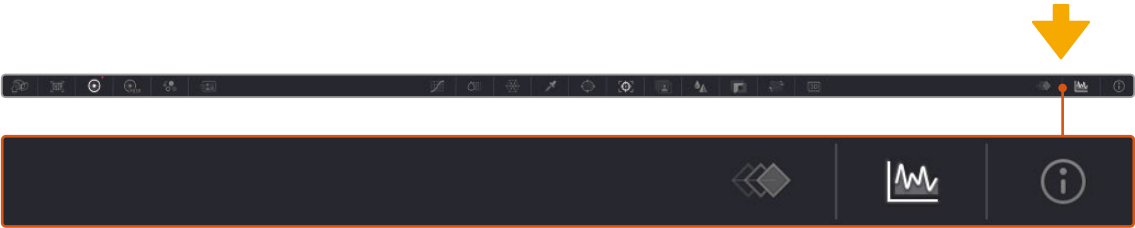
NOTE: At lower resolutions, the Left and Center palettes are merged to fit the DaVinci Resolve interface into a smaller area.

The center palettes include the Curves palette, Color Slice palette, the Color Warper palette, the Qualifier palette, the Window palette, the Tracker palette, the Magic Mask palette, the Blur palette, the Key palette, the Sizing palette, and the Stereoscopic 3D palette.

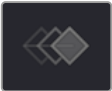


Keyframe Editor, Video Scopes, and Information

The bottom right of the Color page can be switched between one of three things:



The three controls for displaying the Keyframe Editor, video scopes, or Information palette



Keyframe Editor: Provides an interface for animating Color, Sizing, and Stereo Format adjustments over time. Each node in the Node Editor corresponds to a track in the Keyframe Editor, which lets you animate each node's adjustments independently. Furthermore, each node's track can be opened up to reveal parameter groups, so that you can animate subsets of an individual node's functions independently of other functions within the same node.

For more information about keyframing, see *Chapter 148, "Keyframing in the Color Page."*



Video scopes: Provides a docked area where you can expose one video scope at a time for reference while you work. You can also "undock" the video scopes into a stand-alone window, in which you can show four different scopes at a time. More information about using the video scopes appears later in this chapter.



Information: Provides a way of seeing clip and system information while you work.

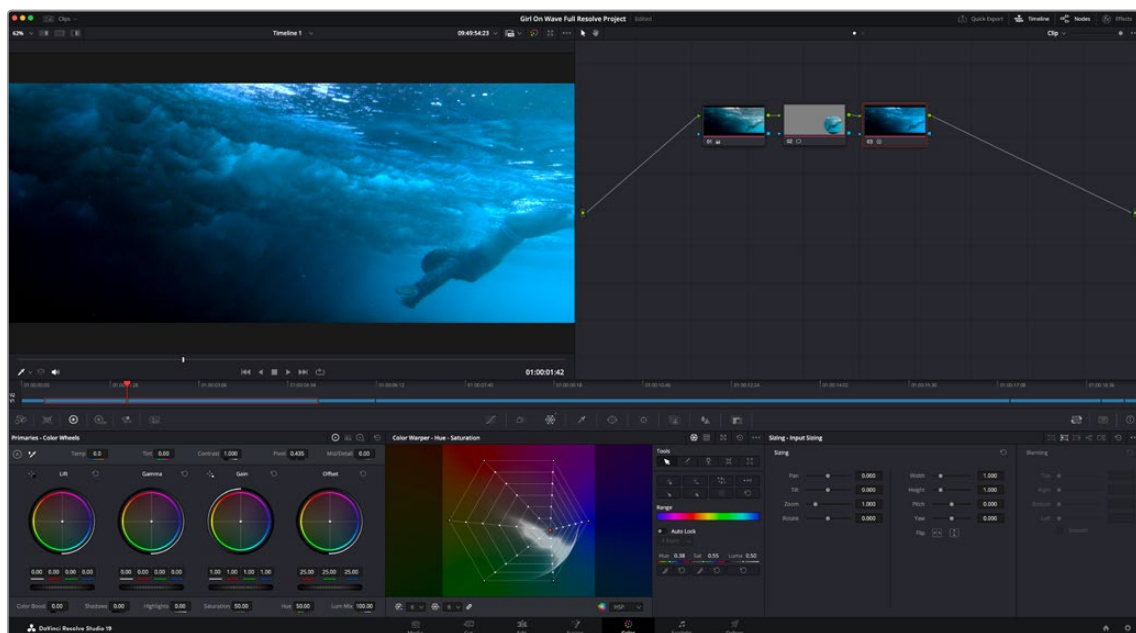
Dual-Monitor Layout

The Color page has a dual monitor layout that provides maximum space for the Viewer, Node Editor, and Control palettes on the primary monitor, and a simultaneously displayed Gallery, Lightbox, Keyframe Editor, Metadata Editor, and Video Scope panel on the secondary monitor. The second screen of a dual-screen layout can be resized, but not reorganized.

If you have an single ultra-wide monitor, you can also use the dual-monitor layout, and DaVinci Resolve will scale the interface as if you had two normal monitors side by side.

To enter dual-screen mode:

Choose Workspace > Dual Screen > On.



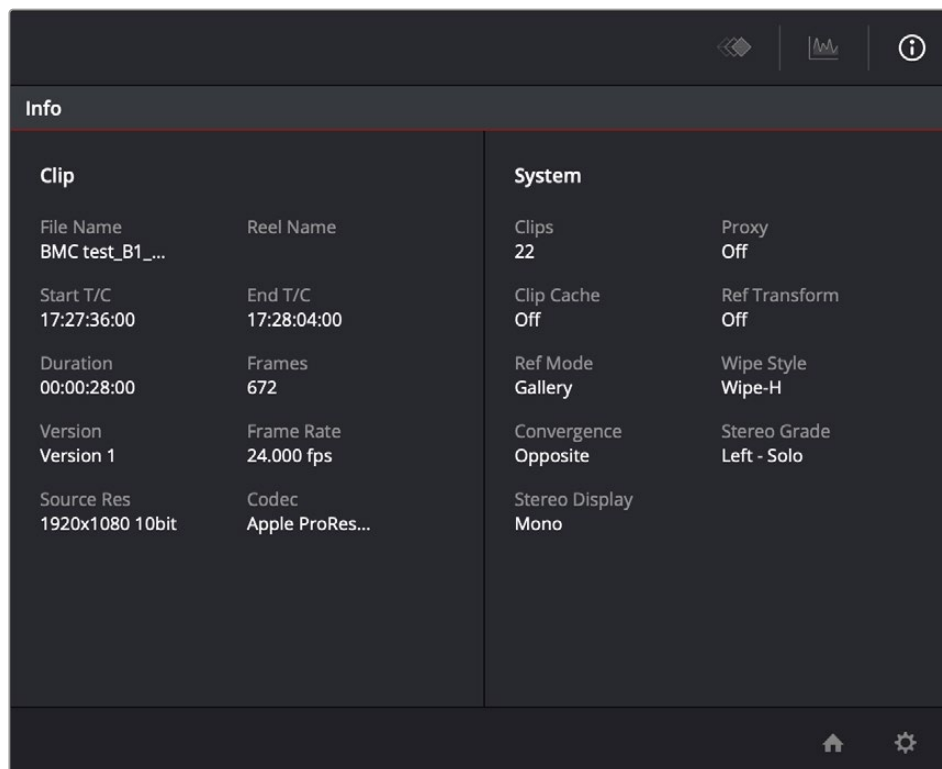
The Color page in dual screen mode

To switch which UI elements appear on which monitors:

Choose Workspace > Primary Display > (Monitor Name), which reverses the contents of both monitors in dual screen mode.

The Info Palette and Clip Information

The Info palette is hidden by default. Clicking the Info palette button at the far right of the toolbar reveals it. The Info palette has two tabs that display different information. There are no user-editable controls in the Info palette.



Info palette displaying Clip Info and System Status

Clip Info

The first tab displays information about whichever clip is currently selected in the Timeline. This information is not editable, but is provided for reference, and includes:

File Name	The name of the media file on disk. If the current clip is a Multicam clip, this shows the name of the currently selected angle.
Reel Name	The reel name of that clip, if one is being read properly.
Start T/C	The source timecode value of the first frame in the clip.
End T/C	The source timecode value of the last frame in the clip.

Duration	The duration of the clip, in timecode.
Frames	The duration of the clip, in frames.
Version	The name of the remote or local version used by that clip.
Frame Rate	The frame rate used by that clip.
Source Res	The native resolution of the source clip.
Codec	The codec or format used by the source clip.

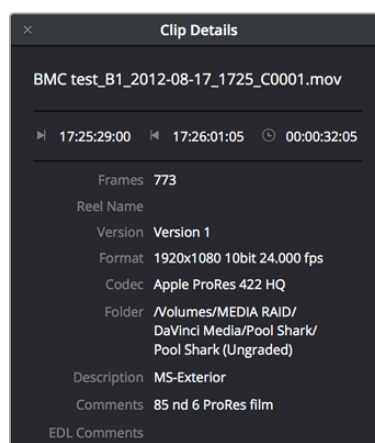
System Info

The second tab displays information about operational modes currently in use by DaVinci Resolve. It's meant to provide the status of different DaVinci Resolve features that can be enabled, disabled, or cycled among various options. This information includes:

Clips	The total number of clips in the Timeline.
Proxy	The status of Proxy mode (On or Off).
Clip Cache	The status of the Clip Cache mode (Off, All, Dissolves, User, User & D).
Ref Transform	The status of Reference Still reposition.
Ref Mode	The status of the Reference mode (Gallery, Timeline, Offline).
Wipe Style	The currently selected Wipe Style for split screens (Wipe-H, Wipe-V, Wipe-M, Wipe-A).
Convergence	The current Convergence setting (Linked Zoom, Opposite)
Stereo Grade	The currently displayed Eye and Gang mode (Left or Right - Gang or Solo).
Stereo Display	The current Stereo Display mode (Mono or Stereo).

Clip Details

You can right-click the currently selected clip in the Thumbnail Timeline and choose View Clip Details to show a small window with all of that clip's information available at a glance. You can drag this window anywhere you like, even to another display.



The Clip Details window

This information is not editable, but is provided for easy reference, and includes:

File Name	The name of the media file on disk appears at top.
Start Timecode	The source timecode value of the first frame in the clip.
End Timecode	The source timecode value of the last frame in the clip.
Duration	The duration of the clip, in timecode.
Frames	The duration of the clip, in frames.
Reel Name	The reel name of that clip, if one is being read properly.
Version	The name of the remote or local version used by that clip.
Format	The format used by the source clip, along with the frame size and bit depth.
Codec	The codec used by the source clip.
Folder	Which directory on disk the source media resides in.
Description	The description field of the Metadata Editor.
Comments	The Comments field of the Metadata Editor.
EDL Comments	EDL comments for that event, if any exist.

Customizing the Color Page

The various sections of the Color page can be resized, hidden, and rearranged as needed to accommodate different working styles. This section covers all of the methods that are available for Color page customization.

You can easily resize the Viewer, Gallery, and Nodes Editor relative to one another to make the Viewer larger, expand the width of the Node Editor to have more workspace, or to create more or less room for stills in the Gallery.

To resize the Viewer, Gallery, and Node Editor:

Move the pointer over the vertical divider between any two areas. When the resize icon appears, drag the divider to the left or right to make one area larger while making the other smaller.

You can also fully expand the Gallery, the Memories, the Node Editor, and the Keyframe Editor to replace completely whichever interface area is adjacent.

To expand the Keyframe Editor, Viewer, and Gallery:

Click the Expand control at the upper right of whichever interface area you want to expand. Once expanded, clicking the Expand control again will collapse that interface area back to its original size, revealing whatever was hidden.

In Display mode, you can completely hide the Viewer, pushing the Gallery all the way to the right side of the DaVinci Resolve window, and expanding the Node Editor to take the rest of the space.

To toggle Display mode:

Right-click in the empty area of the Node Editor, and choose Toggle Display Mode from the contextual menu. Do this again to toggle Display Mode off and return the interface to the way it was.

To show and hide the Mini-Timeline:

Click the Timeline button at the right of the palette button bar.

To show and hide the Color page Viewer upper toolbar:

Click the Viewer option menu and choose Show Viewer Options to uncheck it.

To return all pages to their default layout:

Choose Workspace > Reset UI Layout.

Undo and Redo in DaVinci Resolve

No matter where you are in DaVinci Resolve, Undo and Redo commands let you back out of steps you've taken or commands you've executed, and reapply them if you change your mind. DaVinci Resolve is capable of undoing the entire history of things you've done since creating or opening a particular project. When you close a project, its entire undo history is purged. The next time you begin work on a project, its undo history starts anew.

Because DaVinci Resolve integrates so much functionality in one application, there are three separate sets of undo "stacks" to help you manage your work.

- The Media, Cut, Edit, and Fairlight pages share the same multiple-undo stack, which lets you backtrack out of changes made in the Media Pool, the Timeline, the Metadata Editor, and the Viewers.
- Each clip in the Fusion page has its own undo stack so that you can undo changes you make to the composition of each clip, independently.
- Each clip in the Color page has its own undo stack so that you can undo changes you make to grades in each clip, independently.

In all cases, there is no practical limit to the number of steps that are undoable (although there may be a limit to what you can remember). To take advantage of this, there are three ways you can undo work to go to a previous state of your project, no matter what page you're in.

To simply undo or redo changes you've made one at a time:

- Choose Edit > Undo (Command-Z) to undo the previous change.
- Choose Edit > Redo (Shift-Command-Z) to redo to the next change.